

RH12

Performing Arts: Music, Dance, Theatre, Instruments

About 2-3 questions a paper. At least one is almost always instrument classification or instrument-to-community.

The instrument classification is the highest-frequency single fact in Rajasthan Art and Culture. Tat, sushir, avanaddh, ghan — RPSC asked it in 2013, in 2021 twice and again in 2024. After that come dance-to-community and theatre-form-to-region. All matching, all learnable in one sitting.

Performing Arts of Rajasthan

Tat (string)

- Ravanhatha
- Kamaycha
- Sarangi
- Jantar
- Chautara
- Bhapang
- Chikara
- Ektara
- Surinda

Sushir (wind)

- Algoza
- Poongi/Been
- Satara
- Shehnai
- Karna
- Bankiya
- Nad
- Morchang
- Mashak
- Bhungal

Avanaddh (drum)

- Nagara
- Dhol
- Chang
- Damroo
- Mridang
- Khanjari
- Maandal
- Naubat
- Damama

Ghan (solid)

- Khartal
- Manjira
- Jhanjh
- Thali
- Ghadwa
- Chimta
- Ghungroo
- Lezim

Communities

- Manganiyar
- Langa
- Bhopa
- Kamad
- Dholi
- Bhat
- Kalbeliya

Dances

- Ghoomar
- Gair
- Chari
- Bhavai
- Kalbeliya
- Terahtali
- Gavari
- Walar
- Chakri
- Kachhi Ghodi
- Agni

Theatre

- Khyal
- Rammat
- Tamasha
- Rasdhari
- Nautanki
- Swang
- Kathputli

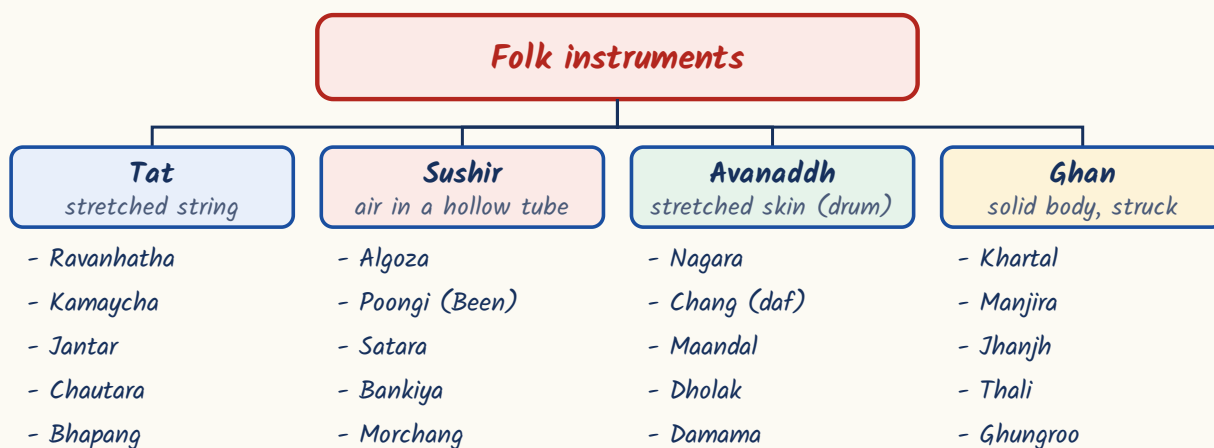
Classical & texts

- Jaipur Kathak gharana
- Atrauli-Jaipur khayal
- Mewati gharana
- Sangeet Raj
- Nartan Nirnay

The four classes of instruments — learn this before anything else

Indian tradition sorts every instrument by how the sound is produced, not by how it is played. Four classes. Tat is a stretched string. Sushir is air through a hollow tube. Avanaddh is a stretched membrane, that is a drum. Ghan is a solid body that rings when struck. Learn the four Sanskrit names and their English equivalents together, because RPSC uses both in the same option list.

How the sound is made - the four classes



The four classes

Sanskrit class	English	Rajasthan examples
Tat vadya	Chordophone (string)	Ravanhatha, Kamaycha, Sarangi, Jantar, Chautara, Bhapang, Chikara, Ektara, Surinda, Rabab
Sushir vadya	Aerophone (wind)	Algoza, Poongi/Been, Satara, Shehnai, Nad, Karna, Bankiya, Bhungal, Mashak, Morchang
Avanaddh vadya	Membranophone (drum)	Nagara, Dhol, Dholak, Chang, Damroo, Mridang/Pakhawaj, Khanjari, Maandal, Tasa, Dhaunsa, Naubat, Damama
Ghan vadya	Idiophone (solid)	Khartal, Manjira, Jhanjh, Thali, Ghara/Ghadwa, Chimta, Ghungroo, Lezim, Ghuraliyo

YAAD RAKHO

Remember: TAAR is a string, so Tat = taar. SU-shir has hawa going through it, so wind. Avanaddh has 'nadh' = tied, so a tied skin, a drum. Ghan means solid metal or wood. Four names, four ideas — and every year at least one question turns on nothing more than this.

ASKED IN RAS

Asked in RAS Pre 2024 — the Chautara, used with Ramdevji bhajans, belongs to which class? Answer: tat (string). It is a four-stringed tanpura-like instrument, played chiefly by the Kamad community. Asked in RAS Pre 2013 — the Khartal, a pair of hard wooden clappers, is which type? Answer: ghan vadya; its great exponent was Sadiq Khan Manganiyar of Jaisalmer.

TRAP

Two classification traps RPSC has actually used. (1) The Manjira is a pair of small metal cymbals — it is GHAN, not avanaddh and not sushir. (2) The Surinda is a BOWED STRING instrument of the Langas, so it is tat — it appears in NOT-a-wind-instrument questions alongside Algoza, Satara and Bankiya, which are genuinely wind. Also note the Morchang, a small iron jaw harp, is counted among sushir vadya in the Rajasthani tradition.

Tat vadya in detail — instrument, community, use

String instruments carry most of the matching questions because each one belongs to a specific community and a specific deity or story. Do not learn the instrument alone. Learn instrument plus who plays it plus what it accompanies.

String instrument to community to use

Instrument	Played by	What it accompanies / detail
Ravanhatha	Bhopas of Pabuji	Pabuji ki Phad; half-coconut belly; called an early ancestor of the violin
Kamaycha	Manganiyars of Jaisalmer-Barmer	About 17 strings, round leather-covered mango-wood resonator; exponent Sakar Khan
Jantar	Gurjar Bhopas of Devnarayan	Devnarayan ki Phad; veena-like, two gourds, 5-6 strings
Chautara	Kamad community	Ramdevji bhajans; four strings, tanpura-like
Sarangi	Langas (Sindhi Sarangi, Gujratan Sarangi)	About 27 strings
Surinda	Langas	Another bowed instrument of the Langas
Bhapang	Mewati Jogi of Mewat / Alwar	Single-stringed 'talking drum'; exponent Jahoor Khan Mewati
Chikara	Garasia and Meo	Three strings
Ektara	Wandering singers	One string

ASKED IN RAS

Asked in RAS Pre 2021 — the Bhapang, the single-stringed 'talking drum', belongs to which region? Answer: Mewat, that is the Alwar-Bharatpur belt. The name says drum but the instrument is a string instrument; that is precisely why it is asked.

Descending order by number of strings — RPSC has built an ordering question on exactly this



Wind, drum and solid instruments

For the other three classes you mostly need the name and one identifying tag. Read once, then test yourself by covering the right column.

- Algoza — a PAIR of bamboo flutes played together; one carries the melody, the other a drone. Played by Langa, Bhil and Kalbeliya musicians.
- Poongi (Been) — gourd-bodied pipe of the Kalbeliya snake charmers; accompanies the Kalbeliya dance with the Khanjari and Dholak.
- Morchang — small iron jaw harp, the 'Jew's harp of Rajasthan', played by Langa and Manganiyar musicians.
- Satara, Shehnai, Nad, Karna, Bankiya, Bhungal, Mashak — the rest of the wind list.

Avanaddh — the drums

- Nagara — the largest of the percussion instruments.
- Chang (daf) — single-membrane frame drum; THE Holi instrument of Shekhawati.
- Maandal — baked-clay drum with one small and one large mouth, used by the Bhils in the Gavari dance-drama, along with the Thali.
- Others: Dhol, Dholak, Damroo, Mridang/Pakhawaj, Khanjari, Tasa, Dhaunsa, Naubat, Damama.

Ghan — the solids

- Khartal — pair of hard wooden clappers; exponent Sadiq Khan Manganiyar.
- Manjira, Jhanjh, Thali, Ghara/Ghadwa, Chimta, Ghungroo, Lezim, Ghuraliyo.

The performing communities

Rajasthan's folk music is hereditary. A family plays one instrument for one patron community for generations. RPSC matches the community to the instrument, so learn the pairs, not the sociology.

Hereditary musician communities and where they belong



Manganiyar and Langa share the same western belt - Jaisalmer-Barmer - but not the same instruments.

Manganiyar vs Langa — the pair students mix up

Manganiyar	Langa
Muslim hereditary musicians of Jaisalmer-Barmer	Muslim hereditary musicians of the same western belt
Play the Kamaycha and the Khartal	Play the Sindhi Sarangi and the Algoza (also Surinda)
Patrons: Rajputs and Charans	Patrons: Sindhi Sipahi
Exponents: Sakar Khan (Kamaycha), Sadiq Khan (Khartal)	-

Community to instrument to deity or story

Community	Instrument	Sings / narrates
Bhopa of Pabuji	Ravanhatha	Pabuji ki Phad
Gurjar Bhopa of Devnarayan	Jantar	Devnarayan ki Phad
Kamad	Chautara / Tandoora	Ramdevji bhajans; Kamad women perform Terahtali
Mewati Jogi	Bhapang	Mewati folk songs of Alwar
Kalbeliya (Sapera)	Poongi, Khanjari, Dholak	Kalbeliya dance songs
Dholi, Bhat, Dhadhi, Rawal	Drums and narrative song	Genealogy and praise singing; the Bhat also perform Kathputli

Folk songs — one line each

Folk songs are asked as song-to-occasion. Nothing deeper. Learn the occasion in three words.

Folk song to occasion or theme

Song	Occasion / theme
Panihari	Sung by women drawing water at the well
Kurjan	The demoiselle crane carries a message to the absent husband
Olyun	Marwari song of longing and remembrance
Jachcha	Birth songs
Halariya	Sung at the birth of a child
Supna, Moriya, Peepli, Hichki, Kaga, Papaiyo, Bandola	Songs of separation, omen and longing
Rasiya	Bharatpur region

YAAD RAKHO

Three of these are named after birds — Kurjan the demoiselle crane, Kaga the crow, Papaiyo the papiha. All three belong to the songs of separation and waiting. If an option pairs a bird with a wedding or a birth, it is wrong.

Dances — region, community, one identifying action

This is the second big matching set of the chapter. Every dance has one physical action that identifies it — pots on the head, thirteen manjiras, a dummy horse, fire. Learn the action and the community together.

Folk dances and their home regions



Chakri is Hadoti (Baran-Kota), not Garasia country; Bhavai is the Udaipur-Sirohi belt, not Shekhawati.

Dance to region to community

Dance	Region	Community & identifying action
<i>Ghoomar</i>	<i>All over Rajasthan</i>	<i>Bhil in origin, adopted by Rajput households; women only; circular ghoomna; danced at Gangaur and Teej</i>
<i>Gair</i>	<i>Mewar and Marwar</i>	<i>Men's Holi dance; Dandi Gair of Jalore-Marwar, Geendad of Shekhawati</i>
<i>Chari</i>	<i>Kishangarh and Ajmer</i>	<i>Gurjar and Saini women balance a brass chari with a lighted lamp; exponent Falku Bai</i>
<i>Bhavai</i>	<i>Udaipur, Sirohi, Dungarpur</i>	<i>Seven to nine pots balanced on the head, dancing on a sword edge or glass; Daulat Bai, Krishna Vyas</i>
<i>Kalbeliya</i>	<i>Western Rajasthan</i>	<i>Sapera community; forms Indoni, Shankaria, Panihari; Gulabo Sapera</i>
<i>Terahtali</i>	<i>Padarla / Ramdevra</i>	<i>Kamad women, thirteen manjiras tied to the body, for Baba Ramdev; Mangi Bai and Moti Bai</i>
<i>Gavari (Gavri)</i>	<i>Mewar</i>	<i>Bhil ritual dance-drama for about forty days after Rakshabandhan; only men, playing female roles too</i>
<i>Walar and Loor</i>	<i>Sirohi and Pali</i>	<i>Garasia tribe; Walar without any instrument, Loor at Holi</i>
<i>Chakri</i>	<i>Baran and Kota (Hadoti)</i>	<i>Kanjar community; women spin rapidly in wide skirts</i>
<i>Kachhi Ghodi</i>	<i>Shekhawati</i>	<i>Dummy-horse dance at weddings</i>
<i>Agni (fire) dance</i>	<i>Katariyasar, Bikaner</i>	<i>Jasnathi Siddhs dance barefoot on live embers to the nagara</i>
<i>Kathputli</i>	<i>Statewide</i>	<i>String puppetry by the Bhat/Nat community; puppets carved at Bassi, Chittorgarh</i>

Ghoomar vs Gair — the classic swap

Ghoomar	Gair
Women only	Men's dance
Bhil in origin, taken up by Rajput households	Mewar and Marwar
Gangaur, Teej, weddings	Holi
Name from ghoomna, the circular movement	Variants: Dandi Gair (Jalore), Geendad (Shekhawati)

TRAP

Chakri belongs to the KANJAR of Baran-Kota, not the Garasia. The Garasia dances are Walar, Loor and Jawara. And Bhavai is the Udaipur-Sirohi-Dungarpur belt, not Shekhawati — Shekhawati's own dances are Chang, Geendad and Kachhi Ghodi.

- Terahtali: thirteen brass manjiras on wrists, elbows, waist and arms; the performer may also balance a pot and hold a sword in her mouth.
- In Terahtali the male singers accompany on the Chautara or Tandoora.
- Gavari is dedicated to Gauri (Parvati) and includes episodes such as Bhanwarya and Khetudiyar.
- In Kathputli the puppeteer speaks through a bamboo-and-leather reed called the boli, and a companion interprets for the audience.
- Two more named dances to recognise: the Dhol (drum) dance of the Jalore region and the Bam dance of the Alwar-Bharatpur belt, named after the bam drum.

CURRENT LINK

Current link (as of September 2026): the Padma Shri has gone repeatedly to Rajasthan's folk performers, and RPSC likes award-to-art pairs. Sakar Khan, the Manganiyar master of the Kamaycha, was honoured in 2012, and Gulabo Sapera of the Kalbeliya community for the Kalbeliya dance in 2016. The state's main annual platform for these performers is the Rajasthan International Folk Festival at Mehrangarh, Jodhpur, held around Sharad Purnima.

Folk theatre — Khyal and the rest

Khyal is the umbrella name for Rajasthani folk theatre in verse. Its branches are named after towns or founders. Outside Khyal there are five or six named forms, each tied to a region and usually to a festival. That region tag is what is asked.

Folk theatre - form to place



Tamasha is Jaipur and Rammat is the Bikaner-Jaisalmer-Phalodi belt. The swap is a standing trap.

Theatre form to region to founder or family

Form	Region	Founder / detail
Kuchamani Khyal	Kuchaman, Nagaur	Lachhiram
Shekhawati Khyal	Shekhawati	Nanuram
Turra-Kalangi	Nimbahera, Chittorgarh	Turra stands for Shiva, Kalangi for Parvati; two parties compete in verse
Hela Khyal and Ali Baksh Khyal	Alwar	-
Jaipuri Khyal	Jaipur	-
Rammat	Bikaner, Jaisalmer, Phalodi	Performed in the open at Holi; nagara and dholak are its main instruments
Tamasha	Jaipur	Bhatt family, settled under Sawai Pratap Singh; performed at Gangaur on a fixed open-air stage
Rasdhari	Mewar	Devotional narrative theatre; the Leela forms belong to the same devotional stream

Form	Region	Founder / detail
Nautanki	Bharatpur-Dholpur belt	-
Swang	Chirawa, Mandal (Bhilwara)	-
Gavari / Rai	Bhil areas of Mewar	Ritual dance-drama

ASKED IN RAS

Asked as a match set in recent papers — Kuchamani Khyal / Nagaur, Rammat / Bikaner, Tamasha / Jaipur, Turra-Kalangi / Chittorgarh. And the NOT-matched version plants Tamasha-Bikaner. Tamasha is Jaipur; Bikaner is Rammat.

TRAP

Unlike Khyal, which is played wherever a crowd gathers, Tamasha uses a **FIXED** open-air stage. That single distinction has been used as a statement in a statement-based question.

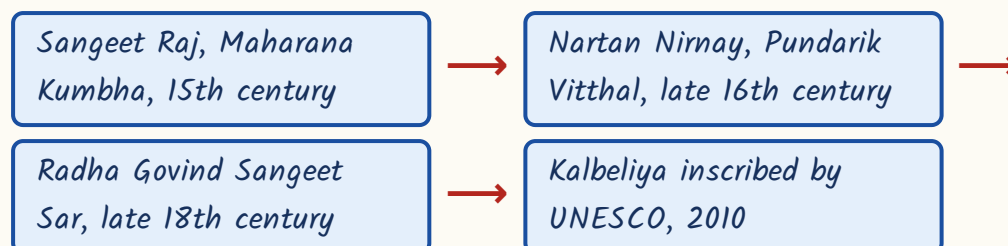
Classical music, gharanas and the treatises

The classical half is short but it supplies the chronology question. Learn four gharana facts and four books. That is the whole section.

- Jaipur gharana of Kathak — the state's classical dance tradition.
- Atrauli-Jaipur gharana of khayal — founded by Alladiya Khan.
- Mewati gharana — associated with Pandit Jasraj.
- Dhrupad was cultivated at the Jaipur and Jodhpur courts.

- Maharana Kumbha wrote *Sangeet Raj*, *Sangeet Mimansa* and *Sud Prabandh*, and a commentary on the *Gita Govinda* called *Rasik Priya*.
- Pundarik Vitthal wrote *Nartan Nirnay*.
- *Radha Govind Sangeet Sar* was compiled under Sawai Pratap Singh of Jaipur.

Chronology of the treatises and the UNESCO milestone



ASKED IN RAS

Asked in RAS Pre 2021 as a match set — Kamaycha / tat, Algoza / sushir, Nagara / avanaddh, Khartal / ghan. Also asked in 2021 as a statements question on the same classification. If you learn only one table from this chapter, learn the four classes.

CURRENT LINK

Current link (as of September 2026): the Padma Shri 2026 list included two Rajasthan folk musicians — Gafruddin Mewati Jogi of Deeg, honoured for the Bhapang and Mewati folk music, and Taga Ram Bhil of Jaisalmer, honoured for tribal folk music and the Algoza. Both awards sit exactly on top of the instrument list above, which is why they are worth remembering by instrument. Note also that the Kalbeliya folk songs and dances were inscribed on the UNESCO Representative List of Intangible Cultural Heritage in 2010 — still Rajasthan's only ICH entry.

REVISION RECAP

1. Four classes: tat = string, sushir = wind, avanaddh = drum, ghan = solid.
2. Chautara = tat, four strings, Kamad community, Ramdevji bhajans.

3. Khartal = ghan, wooden clappers, Sadiq Khan Manganiyar. Manjira = ghan, never avanaddh.
4. Surinda = bowed string of the Langas; Morchang = jaw harp counted as sushir.
5. Ravanhatha with Pabuji ki Phad (Bhopa); Jantar with Devnarayan ki Phad (Gurjar Bhopa).
6. Kamaycha = Manganiyar, about 17 strings, Sakar Khan. Sindhi Sarangi and Algoza = Langa.
7. Bhapang = single-stringed, Mewat/Alwar, Mewati Jogi, Jahoor Khan Mewati.
8. String order: Sarangi 27, Kamaycha 17, Chautara 4, Ektara 1.
9. Chang = Holi drum of Shekhawati; Maandal = clay drum of the Bhil Gavari; Nagara = largest percussion.
10. Ghoomar = women, Bhil origin, Gangaur and Teej. Gair = men, Holi, Mewar-Marwar; Dandi Gair Jalore, Geendad Shekhawati.
11. Chari = Kishangarh-Ajmer, Gurjar and Saini women, lamp on a brass pot, Falku Bai.
12. Bhavai = Udaipur-Sirohi-Dungarpur, pots on head, sword edge, Daulat Bai.
13. Terahtali = Kamad women, thirteen manjiras, for Baba Ramdev, Mangi Bai.
14. Gavari = Bhil, Mewar, forty days after Rakshabandhan, men only. Walar and Loor = Garasia. Chakri = Kanjar of Baran-Kota.
15. Kalbeliya = Sapera, UNESCO ICH 2010, Gulabo Sapera; forms Indoni, Shankaria, Panihari.
16. Kuchamani Khyal - Lachhiram, Nagaur. Shekhawati Khyal - Nanuram. Turra-Kalangi - Nimbahera; Turra is Shiva, Kalangi is Parvati.
17. Rammatt = Bikaner-Jaisalmer-Phalodi at Holi. Tamasha = Jaipur, Bhatt family, at Gangaur, fixed stage.
18. Kathputli = Bhat/Nat community; puppets carved at Bassi, Chittorgarh.
19. Sangeet Raj, Sangeet Mimansa, Sud Prabandh = Maharana Kumbha. Nartan Nirnay = Pundarik Vitthal. Radha Govind Sangeet Sar under Sawai Pratap Singh.